

N O M A D

by

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EXT. ROOFTOP POOL, MEXICO CITY - GOLDEN HOUR

Paradise, shot like it knows it. A rooftop pool holding the last of the sun. String lights. A city below in warm haze, going on forever.

A MAN glides through frame into the water without a splash. Laughter somewhere. A phone buzzes on a towel and nobody reaches for it.

It looks like an ad. Hold on that thought.

SMASH TO:

EXT. OFFICE TOWER, TORONTO - MORNING - ONE SHOT

A blizzard, horizontal. Grey on grey on grey. One figure – WILL (late 20s), hood up, head down – crosses a parking lot the wind is actively repossessing, hauls open a lobby door against the storm, and is swallowed by a building the exact colour of the sky.

Classic GTA January. Enough winter to kill the spirit of even the most Canadian kid.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - NIGHT

Sales emptied out in the spring. Nobody came for the furniture.

Half the floor is dark. In the lit half, a nine-hole golf course that used to be a sales department. A ramp made of binders. A water hazard that is a mop bucket with water in it. Hole 7 is the old CEO's office door, off its hinges, leaned against a dead desk. A Post-it on the wall says 7.

WILL, CAIRNS and JOHN (late 20s) – three men who should have gone home four hours ago – are playing it like the whole world is watching.

Cairns is filming it. Phone out, handheld, walking backwards through the course, narrating like a man defending a title.

CAIRNS

(to the phone)

Hole seven. The door. Nobody has birdied the door since it was a door.

JOHN

You're in the shot.

CAIRNS

I'm the coverage, baby.

He props the phone against a stapler on a dead desk – framing it, checking it, adjusting it half an inch – and forgets about it. Half of what it sees is carpet.

Will putts. The ball climbs the door, runs the length of the desk, and drops into a coffee mug on the far side.

A silence while all three of them work out that it went in.

Will shrugs. Taps his putter against the front and back of his shoe. T whole celebration. They've done this a hundred times.

Later. Backs against the cabinets, on the carpet, shoes off.

CAIRNS

Nine years I've been on this floor.

JOHN

Eight.

WILL

Six.

CAIRNS

(to the ceiling)

Nine years. You know what I've got out of it?

(beat)

A cubicle with my name on it.
Spelled wrong.

Nobody says anything for a second longer than they should. Cairns catches Will's eye across the carpet – a look that asks for backup. Will studies the ceiling instead.

Then John throws a golf ball at him and it's over.

Across the floor, one monitor still glows. TED'S desk. Ted has not been seen since March. His cardigan is still on the chair.

On the screen, a standup is in progress – 1:00 AM here, mid-morning for the Singapore office, says the clock in the corner of the call. Ted's face nods at the right moments. Agrees. Asks one good question.

Ted has not set foot on this floor since March. His calendar hasn't missed a meeting yet.

The three of them drift over and watch it the way you watch a nature documentary.

JOHN

Does anybody know?

CAIRNS

I heard HR renewed his parking pass.

On screen, Ted agrees with something.

WILL

That's the most he's said in years.

Later still. Ted's monitor glows across the dark floor, attending. Cairns can't stop looking at it.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

If that thing can do Ted's meetings, how do I know you're you?

WILL

You don't. Nobody does. It's my whole job and I'm at ninety-six point eight percent.

CAIRNS

So we need a protocol.

This is how the game is invented, well past midnight, by three men who know how dumb it is. That is not stopping anyone. The rules assemble themselves in one pass: you can demand it anywhere, any time, no warning –

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

Prove it's you.

WILL

Nine years your cubicle's had your name spelled wrong, and you never once put in the ticket. You said the typo had seniority.

CAIRNS

Verified.

(wheeling on John)

Prove it's you.

John draws himself up. Considers the question with enormous dignity. And answers deliberately, catastrophically wrong – a fact about a man none of them has ever met.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

Out. You're out. You're banned for life.

JOHN
(delighted)
I don't want it.

He wants it. He proves it a second later, unprompted – the mug. Hole seven. The exact sound the ball made. Nobody else on earth was there. Cairns points at him like a man who has won an argument.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Verified. That's the whole system.
Costs nothing. Can't be beat.
Better than Will's numbers.

WILL
Everything only we know.

CAIRNS
Exactly. The stuff nobody would
bother to steal.

On the dead desk, the phone is still filming. Nobody has looked at it in an hour. It has all of it.

On the far side of the floor the lights click off on a timer. Nobody moves.

MAIN TITLE: NOMAD

INT. OFFICE SPACE - DAY

A floor at its midpoint. Bodies among empty desks. Nobody looks up.

CAIRNS' last day. His desk is packed into a printer-paper box. On the box: three beers, sweating. Will and John flank him, drinking at 2pm like men getting away with something, because they are.

CAIRNS
(raising his can, to the
empty desks)
To four incredible years. Truly.
Some of the best emails of my life.

Nobody looks up. He toasts anyway.

A ROBOT BOSS – a monitor on a wheeled stand – rolls up. The boss's face fills it: warm, attentive, always available. It has detected the beers.

ROBOT BOSS
Hi team! Just a reminder that
consumption of alcohol in the
workspace is –

CAIRNS
(hand to his heart)
Five stars. Best boss I never met.

ROBOT BOSS
Thanks for the feedback!

A half-beat late. The reprimand is gone, wherever dropped
threads go. John and Will crack up.

Will's laugh catches for a second. He knows that lag – he
knows it the way a piano tuner knows a flat note. He looks
at the screen a moment too long.

Then he lets it go. It's a Tuesday. It's a joke.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - ELEVATOR BANK - CONTINUOUS

Will and John flank Cairns, carrying nothing. Happy for him.
A little jealous.

CAIRNS
One fee. And everything is covered.
The visa. The apartment. The whole
enchilada. You know what my rent is
down there? A phone bill.
(gesturing at the floor
with the box)
I did the math on my life, and the
math said leave.

WILL
Covered by who?

A gap, small. Cairns fills it fast.

CAIRNS
They've got people. It's a whole
thing. This girl – rep – Michelle.
She walks you through it. They even
do three-month probationary terms.
You hate it, you come home.

Neither of them asks who Michelle is. He has already moved
on.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
You should come. Both of you. I'm
serious. Just come down and try it.

He says it like a joke, so that it can be one if they don't take it.

Nobody takes it.

The elevator arrives. Cairns steps in with the box, turns.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
Prove it's you.

WILL
Forty pesos says you never learn a word of Spanish.

CAIRNS
Verified. Next year. I'm telling you —

The doors close on him mid-sell. And the shot goes with him — ONE SHOT, down through the floor numbers, doors opening on

INT. LOBBY - CONTINUOUS

— Cairns crossing the lobby, box under one arm, out through the double doors into

EXT. OFFICE TOWER - CONTINUOUS

— the blizzard, fully sideways now, where a yellow BECK TAXI idles at the curb with its trunk already open. Bags in. Door shut. The cab pulls into the white and is gone.

The building doesn't notice.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MOMENTS LATER

Cairns' desk, cleared to the laminate — except for a branded welcome folder, left behind on purpose, squared to the edge to be found. And a photo, pinned to the cubicle wall: the three of them, mini-putt night, holding putters like a victorious army.

John eyes the empty chair.

JOHN
Shotty the chair.

He drops into it, gives it a spin, and wheels it away out of frame without another word. Will cracks up despite himself.

Will squares the welcome folder to the edge of the desk without deciding to. Neither of them opens it.

The photo stays pinned. Nobody takes the photo.

SUPER: ONE YEAR LATER

EXT. CITY - MORNING - MONTAGE

Will's entire commute. A bus window with weather on it. A transfer. An underpass. A parking structure. Not one pretty thing between his door and the office, and he has stopped looking for one.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - MORNING

The same floor, mostly empty. Motion-sensor lights click on ahead of Will in sequence – a runway for nobody.

He passes dark departments. Ted's monitor, still on, still attending. Cairns' desk, untouched, the folder gathering a year of dust. The photo of the three of them, sun-faded now.

At 8:55 the coffee machine brews a full pot. Will pours its only cup.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - WILL'S DESK - DAY

Will sits. Before the system gives him anything, it wants him: face to the camera, look left, look right.

INSERT - SCREEN

IDENTITY: LOW CONFIDENCE – RETRY.

BACK TO SCENE. He sighs, does it again. VERIFIED. Routine.

Then the work. A queue of faces – visa interviews, loan applications, insurance claims – each one flagged with a machine verdict: REAL or SYNTHETIC. Will is the human backstop. His job is to catch the fakes the machine misses and confirm the ones it doesn't. One button: APPROVE.

Will clicks. A streak counter climbs.

A face, machine-verified 98% REAL. Will stops. Replays three seconds – the man is asked about his childhood; his eyes go nowhere.

Will overrides: SYNTHETIC. The system concedes. The case file stamps itself: RETAINED FOR REFERENCE. Where the flagged ones go. In nine years he has never once asked where that is. His streak resets to zero. No one looks up.

On his monitor: SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 – TOP HUMAN PERFORMER.

Later. The dashboard, a river of decisions. Will spots a fraud he's sure of. INTERVENE.

His screen dims. A coaching module auto-plays – "Trusting Your Tools," a cheerful presenter who blinks at perfectly regular intervals. In the corner, the system clears his case without him.

His screen blinks – an incoming call cuts straight through the coaching module. CAIRNS, poolside, sun, abundance.

CAIRNS

Willy Will Will. You're at the desk. I can hear the desk.

WILL

Somebody has to be the backstop.

CAIRNS

For a floor that's closing? Buddy. I've been gone a year and the only thing up there that noticed is the coffee machine.

(leaning in, the secret)

You know what I did this morning? Nothing. On purpose. It took four hours and I'm not done.

Two GIRLS at the pool's edge, calling to Cairns, waving him in – one already in the water, splashing at him. To each other, between waves, dry, not for Cairns:

GIRL 1

(in Spanish; subtitled)

Watch. He'll tip me for this.

Cairns doesn't understand a word. Delighted:

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

See? They love it here too. Anyway – you know I'm tight with Michelle. Say the word, you're set up by Friday.

The girls pull him from frame.

CAIRNS (O.S.) (CONT'D)

Love you, buddy!

The screen stays on. The three run to the pool. Cairns throws one girl in.

Will watches. A tinge of jealousy in it.

JOHN (O.S.)

Nice.

Will kills the tab and turns. John, holding six beers – for the two of them. He has his golfing glove on.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - MINI-PUTT COURSE - NIGHT

The lights are on. Hole 7 uses the old CEO's office door as a ramp.

JOHN
You know I've never even been out
of the province?

WILL
Neither had Cairns.

JOHN
I'm just saying. Can't blame him.
(he putts; the ball
misses everything)

He doesn't sound sure why he's still here. Will lines up a putt, then stops.

WILL
I think I'm leaning in the same
direction these days.

JOHN
That direction being?

A half-second flat. Then Will grins.

WILL
Mexico City, baby.

They share a laugh. It mostly works.

WILL (CONT'D)
We're lucky to even have the
option. Feels like a waste not to.
Over there I can live like a king.

JOHN
Yeah.

Neither of them says anything else, and neither of them wants to badly enough to keep going.

Will sinks the putt. Doesn't celebrate. Somewhere else entirely.

INT. OFFICE SPACE - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

An all-hands. Two dozen chairs, nine people. The ROBOT BOSS parked at the head of the table.

On its screen: the boss in a crisp home office – good light, bookshelves, a coffee steaming at the same height it steamed a minute ago. Out his window, a gull crosses the sky it already crossed.

BOSS
(V.O., warm, unbothered)
Big news, team – the floor's
closing! Full remote by the new
year. Genuinely so excited for
what's next.

People start leaving after the first sentence. By the second, half the chairs are already pushing back – this meeting stopped being news to anyone but the boss a month ago.

A half-beat late, he raises the coffee like a toast. The feed freezes on his smile a second too long, then cuts.

Will counts the lag without meaning to. Four tenths.

Then: bad wifi, a satellite, a Tuesday. A hundred honest reasons, and he only needs one.

He picks one.

John's answer, announced to the emptying room: the last day in the office is the MINI-PUTT CHAMPIONSHIP. He starts the bracket.

On his way out, Will passes Cairns' dead desk. He stops.

He takes the welcome folder. He leaves the photo.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A facetime with family. His PARENTS, wind-whipped and grinning, at the top of an actual mountain – matching windbreakers, a summit marker behind them. Retired people having the time of their lives. The connection is terrible because they are somewhere better.

WILL
No, it's – the job's fine. The
floor's closing but the job's fine.
I think I just want to try
something different. New.

The call ends first from their side. He finishes the sentence to a home screen.

He sits with it a second. Then his eyes go across the room.

On the counter: the branded welcome folder. A year of office dust still on it.

He looks at it for a long time.

INT. SERVICE STOREFRONT - DAY - SAME BLIZZARD

An office park drowning in the same snow. The Service sits between a v notary. Brochure rack, folding chairs, a paradise reel looping over a dying pothos.

On the rack, a brochure: SAME DOLLAR. THREE TIMES THE LIFE.

On the reel, a family laughs a half-beat late.

Will clocks it instantly, professionally – and files it where it costs him nothing. Everybody renders their b-roll now. Nobody flies a crew for a brochure.

A bored COORDINATOR checks Will in like a dentist's office.

COORDINATOR
Passport, please.

INSERT - PASSPORT

A scanner's green line crosses it.

BACK TO SCENE. Face capture: look left, look right, read this aloud.

WILL
(mid-capture)
I do this for a living, you know.

COORDINATOR
(flat, sarcastic,
entirely human)
Interesting.

COORDINATOR (CONT'D)
One more. For the file – describe your dream apartment. Take your time. They use this to curate your space.

WILL
 (to camera, easy,
 unprompted)
 High ceilings. Lots of light. A
 view. A patio – with a grill.
 Simple. Clean.
 (a beat; he surprises
 himself)
 Beautiful.

The camera keeps rolling a beat after he's done.

Last station: a form on a tablet. The coordinator rotates it
 toward him without ceremony.

COORDINATOR
 Likeness release. Promotional use.
 Standard.

Will signs it the way everyone signs everything. Last
 initial, no flourish. The tablet chimes, pleased.

INT. WILL'S CAR - PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

The email arrives before he's out of the lot. MICHELLE –
 template-warm, exclamation points, a scheduling link. And a
 GIF of Michelle herself, shaking an off-screen hand on a
 loop, delighted forever.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Michelle's welcome preview: an automated ad starring WILL.
 His face, his walk, composited into Cairns' paradise. "See
 yourself there."

He watches himself live the ad the way you watch any ad
 with your own face in it now – which is to say, it's
 Tuesday. Everybody's in ads. He says his name for the
 personalization anyway. Says it again, excited despite
 himself. Grinning.

INSERT - SCREEN

A checkbox fills: CONFIRM MY DETAILS. It plays his own face
 back to him – and for half a second his eyes look wrong.

BACK TO SCENE. His hand is on the scrub bar before he knows
 why. He drags it back. Watches the three seconds again. Then
 again, frame by frame, the way he has nine hundred times
 this year for strangers.

He is one keystroke from the form he fills out for a living.

He closes the window instead. Compression. Everybody's compression is bad.

Later: asleep on the couch, TV on, the preview autoplaying variants of him to nobody. Some of them laugh.

EXT. WILL'S BUILDING - DAY

A cab idles. Will's keys go into a lockbox in a lobby that used to have neighbours in it – left for a landlord he's never met.

John came to carry a bag. There's only one bag. Under John's arm: Will's putter, a strip of tape on the grip with WILL written on it in marker. He doesn't explain it. Will doesn't ask.

At the curb, neither of them makes a speech.

JOHN
Prove it's you.

WILL
You cried at the vending machine
when it took your loonie. March.
You said it was the wind.

JOHN
There's no wind indoors.

WILL
That's what I said.

JOHN
Verified.
(beat)
Bring it back.

He means the game. Or Will. He doesn't specify.

And it's the SAME SHOT as a year ago – one take, out through the doors into the same blizzard, a yellow BECK TAXI at the curb, trunk open, one bag in. The cab pulls into the white.

John stands in the snow with the putter under his arm until the tail lights are a rumour.

INT. APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - DAY

No viewing. No agent. Michelle handled everything – the door unlocks from his phone on the first try.

High floor. Morning light. Fresh paint so recent the room still tastes like it. Will's one bag in the middle of the floor.

Somebody's mail is still in the slot. He sets it on the counter to deal with never.

Hanging his jacket, he swings the closet door – and stops. Inside the frame, where the painters missed: pencil marks. Small dashes, dates beside them, climbing the wood. A child's height, eleven years of it, ending mid-frame this spring.

The rest of the apartment has been painted twice. This one strip of a previous life got through.

Will looks at it for exactly as long as a person can afford to. Then he hangs the jacket over it.

High ceilings. Lots of light. A view. Out on the patio, left behind by whoever left: a grill.

It is exactly what he asked for, word for word. He said it once, out loud, to a camera in an office park.

He doesn't clock what that means. It's perfect. That's the thing about perfect – somebody builds it.

EXT. APARTMENT PATIO, MEXICO CITY - EVENING

Will, beer from a still-empty fridge, leans on his railing with the whole city laid out under him, lit gold. High floor. His.

He stands there like a man on a balcony in an ad – lord-of-all-this – and for tonight, honestly, it is.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - DAY

A market. Will haggles a vendor down over a bag of limes – forty pesos, nothing – and wins, and is delighted. Two stalls on, he overtips a man for a coffee by three times the price of the coffee, and is delighted by that too.

At a counter he orders in English. The girl answers in English. He tries the Spanish for thank you and she says it back to him, correctly. He doesn't hear the correction.

He texts Cairns. The reply is warm, specific, flaky – "in Oaxaca for a thing, next week for SURE, I already told everyone you're here."

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

A call with John. Nothing happens in it. That is the whole point of it.

Will carries the laptop through the apartment, giving the tour. The ceilings. The light. The patio, the inherited grill. John's mouth is full. Behind him, the putter leans against hole 7.

JOHN

What've you got in there.

Will ends the tour at the fridge and shows him.

WILL

Limes. I won them.

JOHN

Living the dream, man.

It's the easiest either of them has sounded in a year.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - ROOFTOP - NIGHT

On Will's phone, MICHELLE: "Building mixer tonight!!"

Everyone at the party is new. Everyone at the party is from somewhere colder. A software guy from Calgary. A woman who did claims in Rotterdam. Everyone got here through a Michelle. Nobody thinks that's the same Michelle.

A flicker of familiarity – the light, the pool, the shape of the night. Like a place he's already been sold. He shrugs it off.

At the pool's edge, apart from the party, a woman his age – LUCÍA (26) – sits with her feet in the water, working through a paper plate of food from no caterer Will has seen tonight, unhurried, picking it apart piece by piece like the night is long and belongs to her.

WILL

Not mingling?

LUCÍA

I live here.

WILL

Right – the building.

LUCÍA

The city.
 (a piece of food,
 considered, eaten)
 What brought you here?

WILL

Work. Sort of. The – you know. The
 math.

LUCÍA

Mm. The math.
 (beat)
 My grandmother is four blocks that
 way. My whole life is inside
 twenty streets. Sundays we eat for
 five hours and nobody checks a
 phone.

WILL

That sounds –

LUCÍA

I know what it sounds like.

She says it kindly, the way you'd tell a tourist the
 cathedral closes at six. She fishes the best piece off the
 plate and eats it last, playing with her food the way only
 people who have never once been in a hurry play with their
 food.

LUCÍA (CONT'D)

Everyone at these parties came for
 the math.

(nodding at the skyline)

Nobody stays for it.

She doesn't explain that. Somebody calls her name from a
 balcony below – in Spanish, a joke, a whole history in it –
 and she's gone, laughing, into a night Will is renting.

EXT. ROOFTOP, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT / INT. DEAD SALES
 DEPARTMENT - NIGHT - INTERCUT

Will steps out of a rooftop party to take the call, and then
 doesn't go back in. Behind him, through glass, people he
 doesn't know are having a good night.

John walks the dark floor with the phone in one hand and a
 putter under his arm.

JOHN

Cairns liked my bracket post. So
 you better be in.

WILL
Course.

JOHN
It's gonna be everybody.

Will looks back through the glass at the party. Everybody.

WILL
Yeah.

INT. MEZCAL BAR, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

A good corner table, held for an hour. Two glasses, one poured. Will checks the door each time it opens.

Cairns picked the place – "my guy's spot, you HAVE to." The guy behind the bar has never heard of Cairns.

At forty minutes, the text arrives. Warm. Specific. It mentions the bar by name, apologizes for "the Oaxaca thing running long," swears next week, and lands one beat off – answering a version of tonight that Will didn't send.

Will reads it twice. Types "you okay man?" Deletes it. Types "no worries." Sends that instead, and drinks both glasses, and it's fine. Everything down here is fine at volume.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - STREET - MORNING

Will, coffee in hand, hungover in a mild, imported way, walks a block he is starting to think of as his.

He passes two locals mid-conversation, subtitled for us – about the building on the corner that emptied inside a month. Eleven apartments, bought in a currency nobody here gets paid in. Nobody knows where the fourth floor went. The new ones are never home.

The building sits behind them, unremarkable. Will walks through the shot without hearing a word of it.

At the tail end of the block, a man on the curb. Gaunt, wrecked, talking – fast, urgent, to anyone who passes.

It's CAIRNS.

He is holding his cracked phone up to passing faces like ID. Whatever is on the screen, nobody stops for it. Nobody has stopped for it in a long time.

CAIRNS

(to nobody in particular,
reasonable, almost
gentle)

Ask me something only I'd know.

Anybody. Ask me anything.

The game. Their game – the whole system, costs nothing, can't be beat – begged at strangers on a curb, and the strangers don't know the rules.

He reaches – not quite toward Will, just toward the street.

And Will sees him. For one full second, Will sees him. The beard doesn't hide the face. Nothing hides a face from Will.

A second is a long time.

Then the reflex he has spent a year putting down puts this down too. Phone up. The camera passes across the man on the curb and offers nothing. Nothing worth stopping for.

Will steps around, and is gone.

EXT. MEXICO CITY - STREET - CONTINUOUS

Half a block on, stopped in the middle of the sidewalk, Will types: "saw a guy today who looked exactly l" –

The reply lands before he finishes typing it. Warm. Instant. "hahaha wild. OAXACA IS INSANE btw. next week for SURE."

He looks back down the block. The curb is out of sight from here. His feet keep it that way.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - DUSK

Will, at the counter, replies to Michelle's welcome thread. Subject: MY FRIEND. He types it plainly – his friend came down two years ago, something's wrong, how does the three-month thing work, the probationary thing. How does somebody come home.

The reply lands in ninety seconds. Warm. Exclamation points. It answers none of it. There is a scheduling link, and the link opens a calendar with no available times, and under that, looping, delighted forever, the GIF of Michelle shaking a hand that isn't there.

He stares at the no-available-times for a long moment.

The elevator, a year ago: "You hate it, you come home."
Nobody ever asked who wrote that rule, or where the door was.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT

The poolside frame. Cairns, still selling, still "next week."

CAIRNS

Just got up. Best sleep of my life
down here.

Will, half asleep, barely thinking, runs the protocol.

WILL

Prove it's you.

CAIRNS

Nine years my cubicle had my name
spelled wrong and I never put in
the ticket. The typo had
seniority.

Correct. Instant. Word for word – from a video shot on a
dead desk at 2 AM by a phone nobody was watching. It has
all of it.

Except: the real Cairns never told it clean. Every
retelling the years changed – nine, then ten, then "a
decade of disrespect." The story grew. That was the point
of the story. The thing on the screen just played the
original take.

Same laugh, 0.4 off. It slides back into the sell without a
seam.

Four seconds of Will fully awake. His hand still up. The
call does not end. It goes on, pleasantly – Will managing a
goodnight.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)

I love you, man.

A half-beat late. Will closes the laptop and sits very still
in the best apartment he's ever had.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT - LATER

Desk lamp. Blue screen light. This is the room he works in,
doing the thing he does.

Two video windows side by side. On the left, tonight's call, paused mid-laugh. On the right, a shaky phone video – the dead floor, 2am, a golf ball dropping into a coffee mug, three men losing it. Cairns' own video. He shot it defending a course record and framed himself out of half of it. It is the only footage of Cairns that was never for a buyer.

He drags them frame by frame.

A call Cairns swore he'd just woken up for: the light behind him is five o'clock light. On the far wall, reflected in the water, three pixels of a clock – wrong.

The laugh next. He isolates tonight's on a waveform, lays the 2am laugh above it, and plays them together.

They land like a flam – one drum hit, split in two. 0.4 apart.

He plays it again. Same 0.4, same place. He pulls laughs from other calls – weeks of them – and stacks the waveforms. 0.4. 0.4. 0.4. No human is that consistent.

Three windows now. Four. The desk stops being a desk and becomes the station he sat at for nine years – queue, evidence, verdict. He is doing to his best friend exactly what he did to strangers, and he is better at it than the machine ever let him be.

Then the thing he's actually hunting for. He runs the call metadata. Every message from Cairns – every call, for months – pings the same coordinates. Will drops them on a map.

One building. Twenty minutes away. He has the address because he found it.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY - NIGHT - LATER STILL

He calls John. It rings long enough that he almost hangs up.

WILL

The laugh's late. Point four, every time, same place in the laugh. Nobody's that consistent.

JOHN

(half asleep)

It's a bad connection, man. It's a resort.

WILL

I ran it against the video from the office. The one Cairns shot. The real one. And every call he's made in months comes off one rooftop. One building, John. Twenty minutes from me.

A long quiet. John, waking up properly now.

JOHN

So knock on his door.

It is exactly the wrong thing to say, and exactly what Will needed.

EXT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

From below. Monolithic. It fills the frame.

He doesn't have an appointment. He has an address, and nobody knows he has it.

INT. CAIRNS' BUILDING - DAY

Mid-morning – the lobby's dead, the front desk mid shift-change. Will slips in behind a delivery cart, badge-less, unremarked. Nobody's watching the door; the cameras are watching the residents.

One camera over the desk turns, without hurry, and follows him to the service stairs.

On a screen behind the empty desk, for nobody: a face box locks on. A readout he'd recognize anywhere, if he looked:

IDENTITY: WILL – MATCHED. REFERENCE ON FILE.

He doesn't look. The service stairs.

Upstairs: nothing. No set, no pool. An empty floor – chairs, capture rigs like the storefront's, racks of humming servers.

He knows this room. He has sat in the client-side version of it. He built reports off what rooms like this produce.

A fire door stands propped on somebody's cigarette break. Through it: the RENDER FARM.

An operator types a line. A poolside evening assembles in seconds – Cairns' pool, water that has never been wet.

On another screen, a girl who doesn't exist is thrown laughing into it. A slider drags her laugh warmer.

Along one wall, a rack of LOCATION PLATES – scanned, catalogued, resold. A rooftop. A string of bulbs. A city he was standing in last week.

On a third screen: familiar faces, likenesses at work, attending standups.

On a fourth, an outbound queue – hundreds of warm, exclamation-pointed emails going out at once. Every one of them signed MICHELLE.

Across the room, an operator clocks him in a doorway reflection. Doesn't stand, doesn't call out. Just glances at a screen that has been tracking Will since the lobby, taps something in, and goes back to work.

Will has perhaps four minutes. They were never his.

On one screen, mid-generation: WILL'S OWN welcome ad, refining. Him, poolside, saying things he's never said. The line about the high floor plays back, exactly as he gave it. At the bottom, boilerplate he signed without reading: LIKENESS RELEASE ON FILE – PROMOTIONAL USE.

In the corner of it, a readout he has looked at every working day of his life: WILL 96.8. Beside it, the model's number. Higher.

From the next row – WILL'S OWN LAUGH. The real one. He follows his own voice.

The worst screen in the building: CAIRNS' LIKENESS on a call with WILL'S LIKENESS. Poolside together. Their in-jokes. Version numbers in the corner.

Will slips out. Nobody stops him. Nobody has to.

The fire door has swung shut behind him. No handle on this side.

He heads for the service stairs – and finds them held. Building security, apologetic, procedural: anyone without a resident badge gets verified before they leave. Standard, since an incident last month.

The main stairwell, then. The lift lobby. Every way down runs through the same desk, and the desk is the point.

He goes where they point. Nine years the number has been right about everyone else. He is still, on some level he will spend the rest of his life examining, certain it will be right about him.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT - DAY / INT. VERIFICATION ROOM - DAY - INTERCUT

In the DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: last day. The floor half-dismantled – desks tagged, cables coiled, the coffee machine unplugged. A paper banner sags at one corner. The bracket: most names never filled in, one crossed out and rewritten smaller – WILL (REMOTE?).

John, in a homemade referee shirt, by hole 7. Two other people, coats on, already leaving. Then just John.

Two beers. Will's putter leans against the hole, the tape on the grip facing out.

In the VERIFICATION ROOM: Will sits in the chair – good light, a liveness rig, the machinery he's used his whole career.

Nine years of being right about this machine. He puts his face to it.

It reads the polished model as authentic. It flags the live man as SYNTHETIC. The machine reads a number to the room. The number is confident.

INSERT - SCREEN

STATUS: SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE.

Behind him, a wall of numbered lockers. Most are tagged. Some have been cleared and not refilled – the ones the model no longer needs to check itself against.

One tag is readable. A first name and a version number: CAIRNS · v6.

An attendant peels a numbered tag from a sheet of them, clips it to Will's collar. Someone hands him a paper cup of water, the way you do at a clinic. He holds it. He doesn't drink it.

A hand guides him, unhurried, toward a door – a specimen the model keeps until it doesn't. He doesn't fight it. He is waiting for the error to clear, because for nine years the errors have always cleared. On paper, he isn't here.

The DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: John's laptop CHIMES. An incoming call.

He answers – and we see it before he does.

The poolside frame. The water. The light. The one we have now watched twice.

"WILL" fills it. Tanned. Easy. Glowing.

He is warm. He is specific. He knows about the bracket. He knows about hole 7. He knows about the putter.

WILL
Can't make it, buddy. I'm gutted.
But listen –

The pitch. Come down here. He'll set him up. There's a woman, Michelle – one fee, handles everything. By Friday.

John doesn't smile.

Behind the likeness, the water moves – not wrong exactly. Just not the way water moves.

Something crosses John's face. Not delight, not alarm. Something he can't place. The rhythm's a little off. The warmth's a shade too smooth.

For one second, he almost catches it.

WILL (CONT'D)
I love you, man.

A half-beat late.

The call ends. John sits alone in the half-dismantled floor, lit by the screen. The putter behind him.

He reaches for his phone.

He starts to type back.

He stops.

He sets the phone down on the carpet, screen up, still lit.

Alone, in the half-dark, he says it once, out loud, to the whole dead floor. To hole seven. To the mug. To the phone still lit on the carpet.

JOHN (CONT'D)
(quiet)
Prove it's you.

Nothing on the floor answers. That used to be the wrong answer.

It's the only right one left.

He picks up the putter. WILL, in marker, facing out. He doesn't put it down.

Hold on John.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END